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An Intentionalist Analysis of Breakfast of Champions

Kurt Vonnegut's 1973 novel "Breakfast of Champions (or Goodbye Blue Monday)" is a difficult book to write about. Like many other works by the same writer, it is witty and easy to read yet disjointed and oftentimes very uncomfortable. Vonnegut's schizophrenic writing style utilized in this novel is fascinating to dissect. In this essay I will be analyzing Breakfast of Champions using the ideas proposed by Susan Sontag in "Against Interpretation" and Alexander Nehemas in "What an Author is."

Similar to how many of Vonnegut's books start, he begins in the prologue by communicating directly with the audience about his intentions when writing the piece. Vonnegut explains that the main purpose of the book is to clear his mind of all of the ugly and discordant "bad ideas" that being alive has filled his mind up with. What follows is a juvenile and unfiltered journey into Vonnegut's head. Peppered throughout the text are Vonnegut's own crude marker illustrations of animals, popular advertisements, private parts, and so on.

The story, among other things, is about how an old and penniless science fiction writer named Kilgore Trout discovers a revolutionary theory that bad ideas can make people sick. He makes this discovery after a chance meeting with Dwayne Hoover, a

Pontiac dealer who is suffering from schizophrenia. Dwayne encounters Trout at an arts festival while having a psychotic break. Having attended the festival in hopes of finding answers in the arts that might fix his illness or make sense of his messed up life, Hoover reads one of Trout's stories. He misunderstands the meaning and goes on a rampage that seriously injures multiple people including Trout. The story is often meandering.

Vonnegut frequently delves into tangents describing the intricately upsetting backstories of the numerous characters and locations, or for him to indulge in some of his trademark social satire. Among its many themes are: racism, capitalism, the idea of people being machines, schizophrenia, and so on.

Part 1: Explaining the Human Experience to an Alien

While Vonnegut does provide the reader with his most explicit intention which is to purge all of his bad ideas. The work, *Breakfast of Champions*, is compelling for reasons beyond getting to voyeuristically take part in his 24 chapter therapy session.

Susan Sontag proposes that in much of western art there is a disconnect between the "content" and the "form" of a piece. The tradition of understanding art as mimicking reality, has lead to a culture that focuses purely on what the art has to say rather than the pure experience brought by the oneness of content and form. Furthermore she posits that interpretation whether by authorial intention or purely based on the text, is in and of itself a destructive act. She argues that even though interpretation of art aims to preserve the core meaning, it will always fail to do so. Interpretation is the translation of one language to another and in doing so it will always alter the art in some way.

As an alternative to this Sontag proposes an “Erotics of Art”, where art is returned to being something visceral and purely emotional. She proposes that the meaning of art should be clear and self evident within it’s form, making it “transparent.” For example, an abstract painting may reject interpretation by having no discernible meaning beyond its appearance and the techniques used to create it.

Breakfast of Champions is a brash and visceral work. Vonnegut describes upsetting and ugly subject matter as if trying to scientifically explain what existence on Earth is like to an Alien who possesses no context or prior knowledge. Mental sicknesses such as schizophrenia and suicide are often referred to plainly as “bad chemicals.” Slavery is often brought up as “using people as machines.” Guns are explained as “...projectiles that cut through meat and bone...” that could “...wreck the wiring or the bellows or the plumbing of a stubborn human being”. Every character is introduced by their race. Every white person’s life is terrible and every black person’s life is worse. Vonnegut pulls no punches. He describes people, America, and the world at large as a detached observer. As if it was all within a petri dish observed under his microscope. In doing this, the ugliness of all of the things, places, and people described becomes apparent.

The content (Breakfast of Champions) and the form (the summation of American life to an alien) do not necessarily become one again. Sontag posits that such a rejoining is impossible. However I would argue that Vonnegut, aesthetically unpleasant as his methods may be, almost succeeds in this rejoining. His clinical approach to describing

all of the junk from his head leaves the reader with a taste of bile in their mouth. By describing the all the ugly bits of the world in the plainest terms and to the best of his understanding, and by being as unfiltered and crude as possible, he brings the meaning back into the form. He creates a work that is full of sickness, perversion, brutality, exploitation, and genitals. A work teaming with all of the bad ideas that he stated he hoped to purge himself of during the prologue. Vonnegut in *Breakfast of Champions* is explicitly attempting to be as transparent as possible.

That said, the strangeness of the form still almost requires some interpretation on the part of the reader.

Part 2: The Creator of the Universe

“The Creator of the Universe” is an idea touched upon frequently throughout the text. Vonnegut has explored ideas about God and creation in many of his other works. However in *breakfast of champions* he uses the concept of “The Creator of the Universe” to explore his own mental state as well as his place as an author. In doing so, he meta-textually breaks down the divide between the author and interpreter.

Foucault proposes a distinction between the concept of the “writer” and the “author.” The writer, he posits, is the human being that creates a text. The author on the other hand, is a cultural mechanism that constrains how a work can be interpreted. Foucault proposes a rejection of the social construct of the author so that interpretation may be free again. Vonnegut, though probably not on purpose, flies in the face of this by writing himself into the story as the Creator of the Universe.

As the book begins to approach its finale, Vonnegut inserts himself into the narrative as a spectator. He watches his creations as they experience the climax of the story he had put them through thus far. He places himself at a table in the cocktail lounge where his two creations, Dwayne Hoover and Kilgore Trout are fated to meet. Just to demonstrate his capabilities to the reader, who may still be struggling to grasp what his presence in the text actually means, Vonnegut plays around with his powers of creation. In the first few paragraphs of Chapter 19, he reshapes the universe to his whims and returns it to normal in the blink of an eye, before pontificating on the nature of time some, and then returns to the narrative.

Vonnegut does not take part in the story in any way, he merely orchestrates it and provides the audience with commentary. He tells the readers that he is the one who created every character and made each of their lives so miserable. He made Harry LaSabra a transvestite in a world that wouldn't accept him for it. He made Wayne Hoobler an ex-convict with delusions of working for a man that hated him for the color of his skin. He made Kilgore Trout poor and old and unheard of, only ever having had his stories published as filler in pornographic magazines. He gave Celia Hoover a husband so terrible that she committed suicide. He made Dwayne Hoover a schizophrenic bigot full of hatred and confusion. He also created the entire universe where all of these terrible things were allowed to happen. Returning to Sontag, he leaves no room for interpretation.

Vonnegut's intention in creating *Breakfast of Champions* was to be as honest as possible about what was in his head and to get those "bad ideas" out. Any meaning beyond this, even if intentional, is secondary. Despite this rigidity imposed by Vonnegut's seeming dominion over the text. That does not mean that there is no interpretive work to be done.

Alexander Nehemas proposes that an alternative to Foucault's proposition of abandoning the concept of the author. According to Nehemas, authors emerge as hypothetical characters within the work, that allow the reader to interpret the piece. So from a text we can create a hypothetical character called the author, and this character does not constrain our interpretation, it merely informs it.

Vonnegut's god-like self insertion into BoC still undercuts this hypotheticalness a great deal but outside of the schizophrenic framing device it is still a fictive text that is limited to its own reality and separate from ours. Kurt Vonnegut, the real one not "The Creator of the Universe", is still limited to his personal intentions as the writer. We the readers may still engage in some free play of interpretation that is informed by this authorial intention that he has given to us in droves in the form of his self-inserted God persona.

Within the text of *Breakfast of champions* he is the Creator of the Universe, and the lives he creates for all of his characters are cruel and unfair because of those aforementioned bad ideas. However, these ideas are not the result of Vonnegut's imagination. They were put there by a universe he didn't create: the one he lives in. All

of the ideas he explores in the book, good or bad, are the result of the cultural mechanisms, whether those mechanisms be parents, teachers, holidays, governments, advertisements, and so on.

Vonnegut is an emergent character from the story of reality. All of the “bad ideas” he lets loose from his mind in *Breakfast of Champions* are ideas that he got from our world. The hatred, the sickness, the pollution, the confusion and so on; were put there by living 50 years on the planet Earth among all the human beings in the country of America. *Breakfast of Champions* holds a mirror up to American society. In a way that is disgusting and affecting.